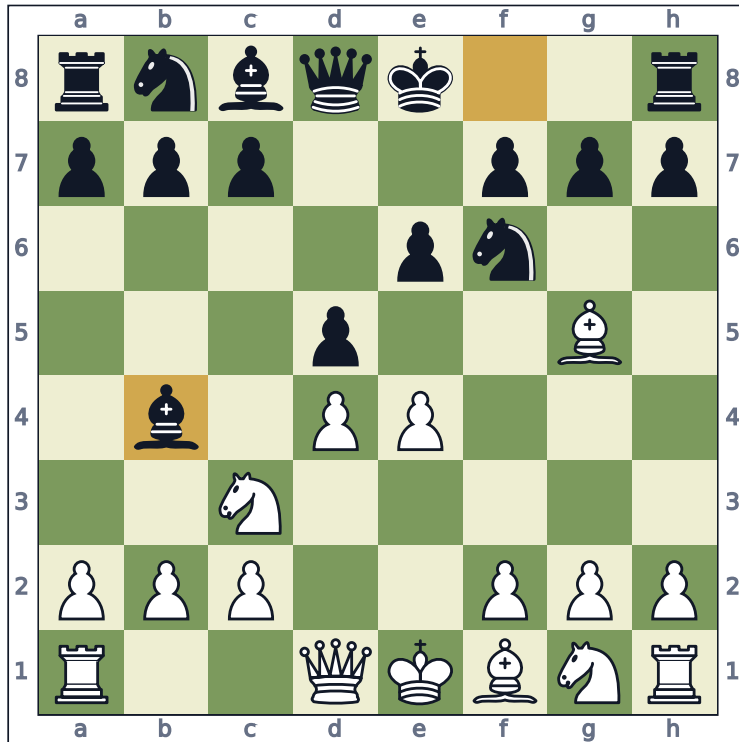


FRENCH DEFENSE

French Defense

ECO C12 | 13 named lines in this code



Featured opening position - gold marks the last move

IS IT A GOOD OPENING?

Good and fully playable. The position remains within a normal opening balance for both sides.

ENGINE SNAPSHOT

+0.20 for White. A shallow opening score is a guide, not a forced result.

GAME CHARACTER

Principled and instructive: development and central breaks lead naturally into the middlegame.

WHAT THIS OPENING IS

C12 covers French Defense. Black builds a d5-e6 center and accepts a temporarily restricted c8 bishop in exchange for a clear attack on White's center. The diagram uses the featured line French Defense: McCutcheon Variation.

DEFINING ROUTE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Bb4

UNDERSTAND THE POSITION

What both sides are trying to achieve

WHITE'S GOALS

Use the space advantage, support the e5 chain when it exists, and develop before beginning a kingside attack.

BLACK'S GOALS

Challenge d4 with ...c5, attack e5 with ...f6 when sound, and solve the c8 bishop deliberately.

PAWN BREAKS - THE ENGINE OF THE OPENING

...c5 is the basic break; ...f6 is the second. White often uses c3, f4-f5, or queenside play depending on the structure.

PIECE MAP

White's e5 pawn can gain space but needs support. Black's bad bishop often becomes active after ...b6 and ...Ba6 or after exchanges. The central pawn placement should decide where each bishop and knight belongs.

WHAT USUALLY GOES WRONG

Both sides can misjudge the pawn chain: attack its base and calculate breaks rather than attacking where the chain is strongest. Recheck the center after every opponent deviation; opening names do not make moves automatic.

POSITION SNAPSHOT

White moves next. Material is level. Central markers: White pawn on d4, Black pawn on d5, White pawn on e4, Black pawn on e6.

WHO SHOULD STUDY IT?

A sound, excellent defense with clear plans and rich counterplay, though cramped positions require patience.

COMPLETE CODE CONTENTS

Every named C12 line

This section preserves all 13 names and defining routes assigned to C12 in the source catalogue. Different move orders can reach the same position; learn the structures and goals before memorizing labels.

001 French Defense: McCutcheon Variation

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Bb4

002 French Defense: McCutcheon Variation, Advance Variation

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Bb4 5. e5

003 French Defense: McCutcheon Variation, Bernstein Variation

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Bb4 5. e5 h6 6. Bh4

004 French Defense: McCutcheon Variation, Bogoljubow Variation

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Bb4 5. exd5 Qxd5 6. Bxf6 gxf6 7. Qd2 Qa5

005 French Defense: McCutcheon Variation, Chigorin Variation

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Bb4 5. e5 h6 6. exf6

006 French Defense: McCutcheon Variation, Dr. Olland Variation

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Bb4 5. e5 h6 6. Bc1

007 French Defense: McCutcheon Variation, Duras Variation

1. e4 e6 2. Nc3 d5 3. d4 Nf6 4. Bg5 Bb4 5. e5 h6 6. Bd2 Bxc3 7. bxc3 Ne4 8. Qg4 Kf8 9. Bc1

008 French Defense: McCutcheon Variation, Exchange Variation

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Bb4 5. exd5

009 French Defense: McCutcheon Variation, Grigoriev Variation

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Bb4 5. e5 h6 6. exf6 hxg5 7. fxg7 Rg8 8. h4 gxh4 9. Qg4

COMPLETE CODE CONTENTS

Every named C12 line

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010 French Defense: McCutcheon Variation, Janowski Variation

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Bb4 5. e5 h6 6. Be3

011 French Defense: McCutcheon Variation, Lasker Variation

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Bb4 5. e5 h6 6. Bd2 Bxc3

012 French Defense: McCutcheon Variation, Lasker Variation

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Bb4 5. e5 h6 6. Bd2 Bxc3 7. bxc3 Ne4 8. Qg4 g6

013 French Defense: McCutcheon Variation, Tartakower Variation

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Bb4 5. e5 h6 6. Bd2 Nfd7